

M01: English(es) and Language Change

Task 1: Experiment: How English has changed

Choose one of the quotes below and rewrite it into your English. Feel free to use spoken style slang, etc.

Sample: Qur'an – Surah Al-Hujurat (49:13)

"O mankind, We have created you from male and female and made you peoples and tribes that you may know one another. Indeed, the most noble of you in the sight of Allah is the most righteous of you."

🗣️ Possible rewrite: "Hey people — we're all from the same human family. Doesn't matter where you're from or what group you're in — what counts is who you are and how you act."

Or more slangy: "Hey peepz! Doesn't matter what squad you're from — if you're a real one, that's what makes you great. 💯"

1. William Shakespeare – *Twelfth Night* (1601)

*"If music be the food of love, play on,
Give me excess of it, that surfeiting,
The appetite may sicken, and so die."*

2. Jane Austen – *Pride and Prejudice* (1813)

"It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune, must be in want of a wife."

3. Charles Dickens – *A Christmas Carol* (1843)

*"Bah! Humbug!" said Scrooge.
"I don't make merry myself at Christmas, and I can't afford to make idle people merry."*

4. Bible (King James Version, 1611) – Psalm 23

*"The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.
He maketh me to lie down in green pastures:
he leadeth me beside the still waters."*

English – past to present

The history of English

English has been influenced by numerous factors that contributed to its evolution. Beginning with the Roman conquest of Britain in 43 AD, English has absorbed words from over 350 languages. Its total number of words is estimated at one million compared to German with 400,000 or French with 100,000. Several thousand words were borrowed from Germanic tribes and the Vikings. Tens of thousands of French words entered English after the Norman invasion in 1066 had brought a French-speaking duke to the English throne who made French the official court language. Other important influences which shaped the way English is spoken today were the roughly 2,000 words William Shakespeare coined for his theatre plays and those added by the newly translated King James Bible of 1611. Regional accents, jargons and other varieties spoken by particular social classes have contributed to even more diversity. English expanded further with new words used by speakers in England's overseas settlements like America and Australia or countries under colonial rule in Africa and Asia who needed to describe their surroundings. Not surprisingly, the spread of the British Empire until 1914 brought English to about 400 million people and caused new varieties to develop worldwide, like Jamaican English. Another variety is Chinglish (Chinese + English). This multicultural dimension makes English truly unique.

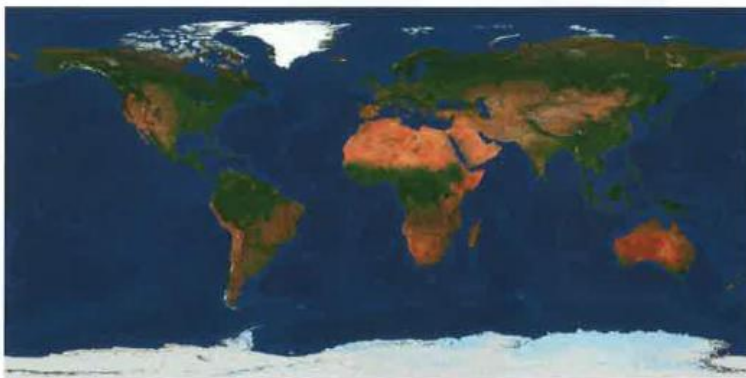
► More info 

The importance of English

Today, English is the global language of politics, business, science, technology and travel spoken by a quarter of the world's population. It is also the official language in more than 50 countries. In others, like India, where no single national language exists, English serves the function of a *lingua franca*, a second language to facilitate communication. Some English variants, e.g. Pidgin English of West Africa, are simplified versions with combined elements of different languages. Non-native speakers of English actually outnumber native speakers by 3 to 1 and English has become the most popular second language globally. As English has achieved its status due to the political and economic impact and cultural influence of the nations where it is spoken, there are also fears that these nations may gain too much power.

The future

English has taken root worldwide despite its complexity and huge vocabulary. The spoken words often sound unlike their written forms and English spelling is complicated. An effort to simplify international communication by using an easy English version called Globish for business and trade has not been overly successful. When asked about the future of English, experts suggest that more varieties of English will evolve and that people will speak three versions of English: their home dialect, a national standard for work and school and an international standard English with a basic vocabulary and simpler grammar which foreigners can understand.



Task 2: New words and phrases:

- Find three phrases in the text on page 2 that are new to you, two that you find interesting and one that you want to add to your English vocabulary.
- Explain the phrases from (a) in English. Use a dictionary if necessary.
- In a group, present an explanation of your phrases. The others need to guess which one you are referring to. Take turns. Add at least one phrase and its explanation from your partners to your list.

Task 3: Chunks to talk about English

- Find suitable verbs for the blanks to form chunks (frequent expressions). You can check in the text for help but also add other verbs.

English has ... words from over 350 languages	... the function of a <i>lingua franca</i> .
The spread of the British empire has ... new varieties to develop → "make it so"	English has ... its status due to...
Non-native speakers ... native speakers 3:1	Globish, an effort to ... international communication, was not successful.

- Compare your chunks with a partner and add new ones to your list.

Task 4: Start a (Mind)Map:

- Over the course of the next weeks, you will regularly be asked to add to a map of English varieties + mind map
- Include any new knowledge about the English-speaking world, but also words and phrases which help you talk about the topic.
- To get started, ...
 - o name three countries or regions whose languages have influenced the English language and briefly note the reasons for this.
 - o name at least four countries or regions where varieties of English are spoken today. Outline reasons for the emergence of these varieties
- You may additionally include any information you find important from the Glossary (M00). You will need the glossary during the next lesson, so it is beneficial to prepare already.